

Tech detox vacation

As I write this, I'm contemplating the next six weeks of my daughter's summer vacation. My wife's super busy creating a list of all sorts of activities she thinks our daughter should sign up for, from offline visits to online edutainment sessions, trying to underscore why it's critical our daughter (who's in primary school) shouldn't 'waste' all her vacation doing nothing. While my wife does have a point, I don't think doing nothing necessarily equals wasting time, especially for a nine-year-old trying to enjoy her summer vacation.

I remember being a nine-year-old in the early 1990s, where all I ever wanted to do in summer vacation days was to play cricket with my building friends until my clothes were soaked with sweat, rent ₹10 movie VHS tapes from video libraries to watch in the evenings, watch cartoons in between and play videogames on a knock-off SNES at my best friend's place till late into the night. So many hours spent playing everything from Donkey Kong to Super Mario Bros, Excite Bike to Road Fighter (with Superman flying by, remember?), Smash Tennis to Duck Hunt, Contra to Urban Strike, and so many more 8-bit games! This was before moving on to Sega MEGA Drive, Dreamcast and eventually the PS1. Looking back now, I wouldn't call all that time spent playing all those video games as time wasted. It's what most urban brats from that time used to do, those who were fortunate enough to afford it.

Tech was never the main focus of anything we did in the day, as watching movies on VHS tapes, recording mixtapes or gaming were largely evening activities. Our building kids who weren't big on gaming played carrom or badminton in the evenings, for instance. Regardless, kids back in the day had a healthy balance of real-world hobbies and offline group activities mixed with what they did in front of their televisions or music systems. With or without sunlight, outdoors was the place to be, never alone, always with a bunch of friends.

But kids these days are growing up in a different world, an increasingly tech-obsessed world, where technology and its impact is



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difficult to completely suppress. Where 20-30 years ago there would be a gaggle of kids playing in our building complex throughout the day and early evening, today's kids are all indoors, nowhere to be seen. If they aren't watching television, they're all most likely hooked on to a smartphone non-stop for all their entertainment needs. From playing hide and seek in real life, kids have gone to playing prop hunt in games.

In no small part, the COVID-19 pandemic helped foment these habits among kids – when playing outside suddenly became a taboo of sorts, an unprecedented health risk. When playing 'pakda pakdi' was no longer an option, exploring Roblox and Minecraft became the norm. Everything from attending school, submitting homework, staying in touch with friends over WhatsApp calls, watching cartoons on YouTube, and playing simple casual games started to happen through a smartphone, tablet or laptop. And some of these habits have persisted, even though schools have re-opened.

Why blame COVID-19 or poor kids when their parents (and even grandparents) are equally if not more hooked onto their mobile devices “to pass time”? After all, kids learn by observation and the onus is ultimately on parents to not just talk the talk but walk the walk. Parents need to demonstrate balance in their technology habits, in order to set the right example and expectation at home for their children to follow, regardless of whether it's school day or summer vacation.

As much as I think today's kids can't be fully sheltered from a modern, tech-enabled lifestyle, if they are to inherit a future that's going to be even more technologically advanced, I do temper that geeky exuberance in me with the concern of a father who's concerned about technology's dangerous inroads into a nine-year-old's life. That means reduced access to smartphones and the internet during vacation, and more time invested in “extra curricular activities”. Demonstrating through actions, not just mere words, that there's more to experience in this world than can be seen through a digital screen. ■



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